BODY, SOUND, AND THE EMBODIMENT OF FEAR: INDONESIAN IMMIGRANTS IN THE UNITED STATES

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TRiO
RONALD E. McNAIR POST-BACCALAUREATE ACHIEVEMENT PROGRAM

ABSTRACT

Looking specifically at the experience of immigrants to the United States from Southeast Asia especially Indonesia, this project studies the ways in which bodies respond to certain sounds within the context of their lack of stable, legal, 'documented' status. The implementation of laws severely limits and threaten the very existence of the narrow spaces in which they live. Furthermore, their fear is often provoked by everyday sounds that have come to symbolize the regulation of such bodies. This project also looks at places from which immigrants have arrived and what kinds of myths from their place of origin may be connected to their responses to sound.

BACKGROUND

This project addresses the study of body, sound, and the embodiment of fear in the making of global cities in the United States. Looking specifically at the experience of Indonesian immigrants to the United States, this project aims to understand the ways undocumented bodies find housing, employment, and community outside of the vision/awareness of authorities and much of the rest of society as well as how these immigrants respond to certain sounds within the context of immigrant's lack of stable, legal, 'documented' status. Many of these immigrants were either political asylee who escaped the 1998 ethnic riots in Indonesia or individuals who entered the country for economic reasons.

Research Question

What kinds of cultural or political references have contributed to the formation of their memory and the formation of alliances among immigrants?

RESEARCH PURPOSE

To understand how cultural differences influence the ability of individuals and community to participate in their new environment.

OBSERVATIONS

- This project focuses on life in a South Philadelphia area which is home to a diverse community of recent Asian immigrants, together with a mixture of black and white working class U.S. citizens.
- There are thought to be approximately **6000 Indonesian immigrants** in the area, many of whom are undocumented.
- A large percentage of these immigrants came to the United States to seek political asylum, but many also came on a tourist visa and overstayed.
- The neighborhood is also home to 15 Indonesian Christian churches. These safe havens are connected to and funded by various American religious organizations, including the Mennonites.
- Public spaces within neighborhood area provides a certain security. However, these spaces are also conduits for exploitation.

FIGURE 1: **One of the local mosques in South Philadelphia area. This is an example of one of the public places where immigrants sought refuge.**



FIGURE 2: **Memories of home country as portrayed in this collage made by students in South Philadelphia. The school is mainly attended by immigrants' children.**



METHODOLOGY

Ethnographic study
Data collection via **direct, first hand observations**

1) Participants Observation
Observed economic, social, religious and cultural spaces within a neighborhood in South Philadelphia.

2) Interviews
- Audio recording
- Filming

3) Site Visits
Visited various religious establishments such as churches and mosques as well as public/social spaces such as schools, day care centers, and Asian markets.

Footage of 'invisible' immigrant bodies moving through public spaces was documented with intention of portraying the juxtaposition to movement and interaction within the 'safer' confines of church and home.

DISCUSSION

The lives of these immigrants are almost never completely secure; they exist in a state of fluidity, ready to change location or identity at a moments notice, in hopes of staying one step ahead of immigration officers, police, and even sometimes neighbors and fellow immigrants.

Within such tense environments, immigrant bodies become attuned to signals, which for others may blend seamlessly into the everyday fabric of urban sights and sounds, reacting in fear to 'nothing' while simultaneously stifling the outward signs of fear in an attempt to remain unseen.

FUTURE RESEARCH DIRECTION

Consisting of a team of scholars whose work intersects in the fields of dance, film, cultural studies, music (sound), and anthropology, this project is interdisciplinary in nature and will provoke new methodological innovations in the study of immigrants in global migration.